beginning of the twenty-first century, Pakistan's geo-political importance to China was growing. China saw Pakistan as more than just a counterbalance to India in South Asia; it also regarded Pakistan as an outlet and a critical base for a Chinese presence in the Indian Ocean. After 9/11, the Pakistan Army became a double insurance policy for China, against the threat of Islamic radicalism spreading from Pakistan-Afghanistan into Xinjiang, and against fears of American subversion of China's ethnic-minority regions in the West. In turn, Pakistan began to depend on China to defend it, especially after 9/11 when the world began to see it as a sponsor of terrorism. Pakistan had come to expect that China would defend its actions and protect its interests in global forums, including in the 1267 Sanctions Committee. The 'block' that China placed on the listing of Masood Azhar in 2009–2010 had strengthened this impression in Islamabad.

Besides the India and Pakistan factors, the American factor was also important for China. Both saw South Asia as a strategic territory. During the Cold War, China and America had been on the same side, especially in the Afghan campaign against the Soviet Union, but it was accepted that America was the senior partner where Pakistan was concerned. Pakistan had been an American ally since the 1950s, but by the early 2000s, it appeared to be a reluctant partner in America's War on Terror in Afghanistan. America began to relook its South Asia policy and to readjust its military and economic assistance to Pakistan. On the other hand, Pakistan had secured from China the nuclear and missile assistance to compete with India for 'strategic parity', and China saw an opportunity in the withdrawal of US assistance to Pakistan, to build its own influence. Pakistan was becoming an area of Great Power rivalry. But between 2002 and 2010, the Sino-US relationship was still stable, and it was yet to become fully apparent that the unipolar moment had passed